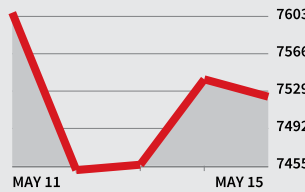


the hindu businessline.

SENSEX 75237.99 (-2090.20)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	23643.50	-532.65
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.36	-0.57
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.96	+1.48
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	157577.00	+7104
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	268500.00	+12900



CAPITAL BOOST.

Corporates must double their technology investments, says Nasscom chief Srikant Velamakanni **p10**

PULSE.

Cash-rich Indian drugmakers are making a global play for the innovation pie **p9**

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MONDAY SPECIALS.

BRANDLINE

Denim major Arvind Fashions makes the Gen-Z cut



Four decades ago, it made a flying entry into India's fashion landscape as the first home-grown denim label. Now, Arvind Fashions is repositioning its legacy Flying Machine brand to appeal to Gen-Z. It is betting on unisex styling and digital-first engagement to revive growth. **p6**

LOGISTICS

Sabari Rail project: An answered prayer?

The ₹505 crore allocation in the Union Budget for the long-pending Angamaly-Erumeli Sabari Rail project has rekindled hope for improved connectivity in Kerala's central Travancore region, especially among pilgrims and agro-industries. Sanctioned in 1997-98, the 111-km rail corridor has remained stalled for nearly a quarter century due to alignment disputes and other related challenges. **p8**

India looks at Oman to reroute \$11.8 b food exports to W. Asia

BYPASSING HORMUZ. New Delhi is exploring the use of Omani ports and land bridges

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Amid the prolonged conflict rattling West Asia, India is looking to Oman for continuation of its trade in essential foods, such as rice, meat, poultry, dairy, fruits and vegetables, with the broader region by routing shipments through Omani ports and land routes, avoiding high-risk maritime zones.

“With the Strait of Hormuz in a state of inactivity, effectively blocking India's traditional trade arteries with West Asia, New Delhi is actively exploring logistical alternatives to continue its agricultural sector exports to West Asia, estimated at about \$11.8 billion annually. Oman is emerging as an effective option in India's rerouting strategy,” a source tracking the matter told *businessline*.

KEY ROUTE

Last week, the Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority held discussions with a visiting Omani

REWORKING STRATEGY

- Unlike most Gulf countries, much of Oman's coastline lies outside the Strait of Hormuz
- Port of Salalah and Port of Duqm remained accessible even as traffic through Hormuz faced disruptions
- India's exports to West Asian countries fell by 28% year-on-year to \$4.16 billion in April



high-level trade delegation to hammer out the operational mechanics of securing the alternative pathway.

“Oman has ports such as Sohar and Salalah and land bridges that provide connectivity to Saudi Arabia and other GCC countries. Already, some of our agriculture exports are going through this route to various markets in West Asia. But costs are high, especially land transport costs,” a source tracking the matter told *businessline*.

In addition to discussions on use of the ports and land bridges to send shipments, Indian exporters also discussed ways in which costs might be brought down for land transportation in Oman as it put additional pressure

on them, an industry source noted.

“Oman's advantage is geographical. Unlike most Gulf countries, much of Oman's coastline lies outside the Strait of Hormuz, directly on the Arabian Sea and Gulf of Oman. Major ports such as Port of Salalah and Port of Duqm remained accessible even as traffic through Hormuz faced disruption. The crisis has shown that Oman can serve as an alternative trade corridor for India when shipping through the Strait becomes risky or unstable,” according to Ajay Srivastava from the Global Trade and Research Initiative (GTRI).

TRADE BOOST

The India-Oman FTA, likely to be implemented on June 1

(according to Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal), is also set to give a boost to bilateral and regional trade.

India's exports to West Asia suffered sharp contractions in March and April 2026, primarily due to severe shipping disruptions and a blockade at the Strait of Hormuz. Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said that India's exports to West Asian countries fell by more than 28 per cent y-o-y to \$4.16 billion in April while imports dropped 31.64 per cent to \$10.47 billion.

Agricultural produce is a major export item from India, with West Asia accounting for 21.8 per cent of total agricultural exports in FY26, valued at \$11.8 billion.

Spice exports are closely tied to Gulf demand, with 70.5 per cent of nutmeg, mace and cardamom exports going to the region. Also, about 98.9 per cent of sheep and goat meat and 97.4 per cent of fresh beef exports are shipped to West Asia.

Dairy and beverages also rely heavily on Gulf markets, including 58.1 per cent of butter exports and 81 per cent of beer exports.

Final CAFE III norms likely by month-end

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

The government is likely to notify the final Corporate Average Fuel Economy (CAFE) III norms by this month-end, with industry executives expressing growing confidence that the long-awaited fuel-efficiency rules are nearing completion despite a last-minute recalibration to align the framework with India's accelerated ethanol roadmap.

Industry sources said the matter had received attention at the highest levels of the government, with the Prime Minister's Office understood to have urged the Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) not to let technical recalibration related to the shift from E20 to E25 delay the final notification.

The BEE is updating the core compliance formula, but industry experts said the revision is technical and will not delay the final rules.

“All the discussions that had to be done have been done. The expectation is that the final notification comes out by the end of this month,” a top automotive industry executive involved in every round of consultations with the government told *businessline*.

Details p3

Prudential buys 75% stake in Bharti Life for ₹3,500 cr

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

In the first major insurance sector deal after the government notified 100 per cent foreign direct investment in insurance, Bharti Enterprises on Sunday announced that Prudential plc has agreed to acquire a 75 per cent stake in Bharti Life Insurance Company Ltd from Bharti Life Ventures Pvt Ltd and 360 ONE Asset Management for an initial cash consideration of ₹3,500 crore payable on completion.

There is potential additional consideration payable of up to ₹700 crore, dependent on the fulfilment of certain conditions, said Prudential, adding that it maintains a strong balance sheet and low leverage.

As of December 31, 2025, Prudential was holding company cash and short-term investments of \$4.3 billion. Bharati Life will be the fifth insurance company with 75 per cent FDI.

Following completion, Prudential's Indian operations will consist of majority-owned Bharti Life Insurance Company and Prudential HCL Health Insurance, and minority shareholdings in two listed entities, namely 35 per cent of ICICI Prudential Asset Man-

agement Company and 22 per cent in ICICI Prudential Life Insurance.

The transaction will be funded from existing resources, said Prudential. Further details will be provided when regulatory consent has been received for the transaction.

“We are delighted to welcome Prudential plc as the controlling shareholder of Bharti Life, further accelerating its growth trajectory. Prudential's experience and global scale, combined with Bharti's strong track record, create a formidable alliance to tap into the immense potential of India's life insurance sector,” Sunil Bharti Mittal, Founder and Chairman, Bharti Enterprises, said.

STRATEGIC TIE-UP

This partnership opens new opportunities for Bharti Life's employees and further reinforces the strategic relationship between India and the UK, he added.

“By acquiring a controlling stake in Bharti Life, we are bringing together Prudential's nearly 180 years of global insurance expertise and Bharti's strong local presence to serve the savings and protection needs of Indian consumers,” Anil Wadhvani, CEO, Prudential, said.

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QUICKLY.

Separate insolvency cases for two Videocon entities

New Delhi: Appellate tribunal NCLAT has upheld separate insolvency proceedings for two Videocon Group entities — Videocon Industries Ltd (VIL) and Videocon Oil Ventures Ltd (VOVL) — while setting aside an earlier NCLT order that had directed clubbing of the two cases. Passing a final order, the NCLAT said creditors of VIL and VOVL had intended the corporate insolvency resolution processes of the two companies to run independently, considering the distinct nature of their businesses and the need for a specialised resolution. »

Hero MotoCorp plans ₹1,500 cr capex for FY27

New Delhi:Two-wheeler market leader Hero MotoCorp has earmarked ₹1,500 crore capex for FY27 to double its scooter production capacity, according to CEO Harshavardhan Chitale. The company has also committed over ₹700 crore of investment in building a global parts centre in the south of India, he told analysts. “We are investing in capacity expansion, and we have committed over ₹1,500 crore of capex in FY27. And this is going to [help us] expand our capacity in scooters. We are doubling capacity for models that are doing very well,” said Chitale. With the firm doing “60,000-odd scooter volume run rate” monthly, when asked if doubling could mean taking capacity closer to 1 lakh, he said, “That’s our ambition.” »

South, West Bengaluru see land frenzy ahead of second airport plans

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Even before the Karnataka government finalises the location for Bengaluru’s proposed second international airport, speculation around the project has already triggered a sharp spike in land activity across the city’s southern and western outskirts. From Kanakapura Road and Harohalli to Nelamangala and Kunigal, investors, land aggregators and developers are rushing, drawing comparisons with the early Devanahalli boom before the Kempegowda International Airport (KIA) became operational. However, property consultants caution that the current momentum is largely sentiment-driven. Most activity is concentrated in farmland deals, plotted developments and land banking, rather than largescale residential launches.

PLUS POINTS

Among the emerging corridors, the Kanakapura Road-Harohalli belt has witnessed the sharpest movement so far, aided by stronger residential infrastructure, metro connectivity and proximity to established catchments. “In the last six to eight months, land prices along Kanakapura Road have effectively doubled,” said Ram Chandnani, Managing Director-Leasing, CBRE India. Areas such as Chudahalli, Somanahalli and Kaggalipura are witnessing strong investor interest due to lower entry prices and the availability of larger land parcels. NRIs and HNIs are actively buying land here, viewing it as a long-term infrastructure-led investment. Plotted developments and farmland conversions remain the most active segments, while developers are building land banks through acquisitions and joint development agreements, a pattern similar to North Bengaluru during the KIA’s early years. Villa and weekend-home projects are gaining traction across the Kanakapura-Ramanagara belt, leveraging both the airport narrative and the region’s natural landscape. According to Anarock Group, the Kanakapura Road micro-market has recorded around 3,400 residential launches since Q1 2024, while the Nelamangala market has seen minimal launches so far. The Nelamangala-Kunigal corridor, meanwhile, is witnessing a more measured rise

Auto exports rise 38%, driven by gains in emerging markets

IN TOP GEAR. Growth visible across PVs, motorcycles, scooters and three-wheelers

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Even as global trade remains clouded by tariff tensions, slowing consumption and geopolitical uncertainty, India’s automobile exporters appear to have found a rare pocket of resilience. April’s sharp 38 per cent jump in vehicle exports suggests Indian automakers are increasingly turning overseas markets into a key growth lever at a time when domestic demand across segments remains patchy. What makes the trend particularly significant is the breadth of the recovery. Growth was visible across passenger vehicles, motorcycles, scooters and three-wheelers, indicating that the momentum is not confined to a single category or market. Industry executives said Indian manufacturers are benefiting from stabilised supply chains, competitive pricing and rising demand for fuel-efficient vehicles in cost-sensitive economies across Africa, Latin America and parts of Asia. **GLOBAL REACH** Two-wheelers emerged as the standout performer, with motorcycle exports rising over 36 per cent year-on-



EXPORT SURGE. Two-wheelers emerged as the standout performer, with motorcycle exports rising over 36 per cent y-o-y to more than 4.26 lakh units in April REUTERS

year (y-o-y) to more than 4.26 lakh units in April. The surge underlines the growing global reach of firms such as Hero MotoCorp, Bajaj Auto and TVS Motor Company, which have steadily expanded distribution networks in emerging markets where affordability and fuel efficiency remain critical purchase drivers. The strong export performance also signals a strategic shift underway in the industry. After years of relying predominantly on the domestic market, automakers are now attempting to build export buffers to offset cyclical slowdowns at home. Executives said overseas markets are likely to remain a crucial growth avenue in FY27, especially as companies push deeper into newer geographies and premium

product segments. “While the current macro environment is uncertain, the demand for our products remains intact across key markets, providing us confidence to recover export volumes as the market conditions improve. Even in an extremely uncertain environment, we are determined to go the extra mile and deliver volume growth of 8-10 per cent in exports as well in FY27,” said Tarun Garg, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer, Hyundai Motor India. HML is the manufacturing hub for many emerging markets, exporting over 3.9 million vehicles to 150 countries cumulatively, he informed, adding that the top five countries include Mexico, Saudi Arabia, South Africa, Chile and Peru. The top models for exports in-

clude Verna, Nios, Aura, i20, New Venue and Alcazar. For Maruti Suzuki India, too, exports saw a growth of around 43 per cent y-o-y to 39,638 units in April compared with 27,729 units in the same month last year, according to the latest monthly report shared by the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers. Bajaj Auto, the largest two-wheeler exporter, said markets such as Nigeria and Latin America are its volume drivers. Going forward, it expects the momentum to continue. The company exported 2,29,890 units of two-wheelers in April, up 78 per cent y-o-y compared with 1,29,322 units in April 2025. “Our wide retail distribution footprint has given us a strong competitive edge, enabling us to maintain an overwhelming market share of 50 per cent in retail terms [in Nigeria]. Latin America continues to outperform, delivering sustained growth for 11 consecutive quarters now and reporting another all-time high performance, driven by strong growth in almost each and every country. The region remains a key driver of our export performance in terms of volume, revenue and EBITDA,” said Rakesh Sharma, ED, Bajaj Auto.

Satheesan announces Kerala Cabinet berths ahead of swearing in today

Our Bureau
Kochi

VD Satheesan is all set to be sworn in as the new Chief Minister of Kerala on Monday after the Congress-led United Democratic Front returned to power in the State after a decade. Satheesan announced the names of his ministerial team ahead of the swearing-in ceremony of the new government. He told reporters in Thiruvananthapuram on Sunday that the list of Ministers had been finalised after discussions among alliance leaders, taking into account social and regional balance within the coalition. He handed over the list of ministers to the Kerala Governor at Lok Bhavan after two days of discussions with allies and party leaders. Senior leaders Ramesh Chennithala, K Murala-Deharan and Sunny Joseph will be inducted as ministers. The other ministers from the Congress are PC Vish-



NEW REGIME. Kerala Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar receives the list of Cabinet ministers from Chief Minister-designate VD Satheesan in Thiruvananthapuram. »

munath, AP Anil Kumar, Roji M John, Bindu Krishna, M Liju, T Siddique, KA Thulasi and OJ Janeesh. The Indian Union Muslim League also declared the names of PK Kunhaliikutty, N Shamsudheen, KM Shaji, PK Basheer and VE Abdul Gafoor as ministers in the new Cabinet. **OTHER MINISTERS** The other ministers from UDF constituents are Mons Joseph, Shibu Baby John, Anoop Jacob and CP John. The UDF also decided to appoint senior leader Thiruvanchoor Radhakrish-

nan as the Speaker of the Assembly, while Shanimol Usman will serve as the Deputy Speaker. Satheesan said many deserving leaders could not be accommodated in the Cabinet despite the Congress securing 63 seats, describing it as one of the party’s biggest victories in the State. “There are many deserving leaders both within and outside the list. But a party like the Congress has to consider social balance, regional representation and several other factors while taking such decisions,” he said.

TVK government faces a crucial call on Parandur airport in TN

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai



The newly-formed Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) government in Tamil Nadu faces a key decision on whether to press ahead with the greenfield airport project at Parandur or risk Chennai missing out on a much-needed second airport. The question is weighing heavily on the minds of passengers, industry and investors alike, especially after TVK leader and Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay had initially backed the villagers and farmers opposing the project over concerns about livelihood loss. As reports emerged that Vijay had held a review meeting on the Parandur airport project, multiple government sources denied that such consultations had taken place. However, with S Keerthana appointed as the Industries Minister and officers of the Industries and Investment Promotion department now in place, all eyes are now on the decision around Parandur. Sources in the know also pointed out that Vijay had only opposed the specific Parandur site in question in the past and not the idea of a second airport. One of the final gazette notifications issued by the previous DMK government declared the Parandur New

Greenfield Airport Project a special project under the Tamil Nadu Land Consolidation (for Special Projects) Act, 2023. The notification was published on March 2, days before the Model Code of Conduct came into force. However, government sources said there is no legal restriction preventing the new administration from discontinuing the project despite its special project status. **MAJOR SETBACK** Industry representatives warned that scrapping the airport project would be a major setback for Chennai. “We have already lost ground to the Hyderabad and Bengaluru airports. Chennai needs the Parandur airport to support industry and passengers,” said an official from a leading automobile company in Sriperumbudur. The previous DMK government had accelerated land acquisition, securing more than 2,500 acres out of the 5,746 acres required for

the proposed airport in Kancheepuram district, with compensation significantly above market rates. The existing Chennai airport currently handles more than 2.2 crore passengers annually. Once the ongoing modernisation works end, capacity is expected to rise to 3.5 crore passengers a year — sufficient for only the next seven years — roughly aligning with the timeline for the Parandur airport to be operational. The proposed airport is designed to handle up to 10 crore passengers annually, and will include two runways, terminal buildings, taxiways, an apron and a cargo terminal. Residents of Parandur, however, are hopeful that the project will be shelved. When industrialists met Chief Minister Vijay recently, the issue of the Parandur airport was not discussed. However, they urged him to focus on infrastructure development. “One of the best meetings we ever had, spent nearly 45 minutes. CM’s willingness to hear is a great pleasure and his leadership is a visionary one,” said M Ponnuswami, Managing Director, Pon Pure Chemicals Group and Co-Chair of the CII MSME National Council & National Task Force on EoDB, on X. Vijay requested the CII delegation to give their suggestions in writing so that action could be taken.

Proceeds of Muthoot FinCorp’s ₹4K cr IPO to be used for biz growth: CEO

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai



Shaji Varghese, CEO, Muthoot FinCorp

Muthoot FinCorp Ltd’s (MFL) proposed initial public offering (IPO) of up to ₹4,000 crore is driven by the strong growth momentum in gold loans, regulatory clarity and increasing formalisation of the gold loan sector, said a top official. Shaji Varghese, CEO, emphasised that the proceeds of the IPO, comprising a fresh issue of equity shares, would primarily be used for business growth. “Since the growth momentum is good and is expected to continue, I think the timing of the IPO is apposite. This money is for growth. There is no private equity investor on board with us. We didn’t want to involve only the promoter family (for capital purposes). So, the IPO is for raising primary money,” he said. As of March-end 2026, the gold loan company’s standalone assets under manage-

ment (AUM) jumped 75 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to ₹56,185 crore from ₹32,055 crore as of March-end 2025. Net profit in FY26 shot up 108 per cent y-o-y to ₹1,640 crore from ₹787 crore in FY25. **LAST RESORT** The surge in gold prices has boosted the business, with the average gold loan ticket size rising to around ₹1.85 lakh as of March-end 2026 from nearly ₹1.20 lakh last

year. Varghese underscored that gold loan is now a very well accepted category of loan. In the past, it was taken only as the last resort. Referring to the RBI regulations effective April 1, whereby lenders are also required to classify gold loans into income-generating and non-income-generating categories, Varghese estimated that nearly 70 per cent of MFL’s gold loan portfolio could qualify as income-generating. Income-generating loans, including MSME loans and agricultural-linked ones, can open up direct assignment opportunities for the company to assign such loans to banks and unlock liquidity. **GREATER FLEXIBILITY** The MFL chief noted that the RBI’s revised regulations also provided greater flexibility on loan-to-value (LTV) ratios and repayment structures for income-generating loans, including longer-tenure EMI-based products that extend beyond 12 months.



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EXTRACT OF STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31 MARCH 2026

(₹ in Millions except per share data)

Sl. No	Particulars	STANDALONE					CONSOLIDATED				
		QUARTER ENDED			YEAR ENDED		QUARTER ENDED			YEAR ENDED	
		31.03.2026	31.12.2025	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.12.2025	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025
	Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited
1	Total Income from Operations	8,641.24	8,331.11	8,322.75	34,928.43	34,121.69	10,946.36	10,369.51	9,354.15	41,855.71	37,733.59
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	320.38	525.88	756.33	2,323.36	3,242.71	509.50	684.51	902.86	2,831.43	3,557.78
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	353.14	469.61	756.33	2,299.85	3,242.71	541.59	627.59	902.86	2,806.60	3,557.78
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	554.54	568.00	567.03	2,283.84	2,469.82	697.26	687.37	679.65	2,669.99	2,599.30
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	553.51	564.99	563.41	2,270.83	2,460.02	749.69	679.74	682.54	2,801.97	2,673.60
6	Equity Share Capital				603.28	603.28				603.28	603.28
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet				14,369.20	12,219.03				16,137.53	13,456.22
8	Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)										
	a) Basic (in ₹)	9.19	9.42	9.40	37.86	41.11	11.56	11.39	11.27	44.26	43.27
	b) Diluted (in ₹)	9.19	9.42	9.40	37.86	41.11	11.56	11.39	11.27	44.26	43.27

Notes:

- The above results for the quarter and year ended 31 March 2026 have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at their meetings held on 16 May 2026.
- The Board of Directors of the Company has recommended a final dividend of Rs. 5/- (i.e. 50%) per equity share of face value of Rs. 10 each for the financial year ended 31 March 2026 subject to the approval of the shareholders in ensuing Annual General Meeting.
- The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Year to date / Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly / Year to date / Annual Financial Results is available on the stock exchange websites, www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com and on the Company's website www.dodladairy.com

Place: Hyderabad
Date: 16 May 2026

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Sd/-
Dodla Sunil Reddy, Managing Director, DIN: 00794889

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QUICKLY.

Space intel giant ICEYE to set up facility in India

New Delhi: ICEYE, a global leader in space-based intelligence, is set to establish its first Indian production facility within the next year to manufacture small satellites for defence, surveillance and environmental monitoring. Rafal Modrzewski, CEO of ICEYE, said the facility will serve as the company's primary manufacturing hub for the Asia-Pacific region, complementing its existing operations in Europe and the US. [PTI](#)

HFCL bags ₹106 cr order for optical fibre cables

New Delhi: Telecom gear maker HFCL has bagged an order of \$11.07 million (about ₹106 crore) for the supply of optical fibre cables overseas, a company filing said on Sunday. The company has to complete the supplies by August. HFCL, in the fiscal year 2026, exported 70 per cent of its optical fibre cable production. In FY26, the company bagged a long-term global optical fibre cable supply contract valued at \$1.1 billion. [PTI](#)

India, Netherlands ink 17 pacts on defence, critical minerals

LEG UP. Dutch Semicon Competence Centre to be connected to Indian Semicon Mission

Press Trust of India
The Hague

Driven by shifting global geopolitics, India and the Netherlands inked 17 agreements to boost cooperation in defence, critical minerals and other key sectors during talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Dutch counterpart Rob Jetten.

In their meeting, the two Prime Ministers expressed deep concern over the situation in West Asia, especially its serious implications for global energy supplies and trade networks.

Modi and Jetten also called for freedom of navigation and global flow of commerce through the Strait of Hormuz, which sees roughly one-fifth of global energy supplies pass through, where shipping has been severely disrupted since February 28. The two leaders also dis-



WALK THE TALK. Prime Minister Narendra Modi with his Dutch counterpart Rob Jetten on Sunday [REUTERS](#)

cussed the situation in Ukraine — marked by the ongoing conflict with Russia and regional security developments.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said in a social media post: “The visit witnessed the launch of a new Roadmap for Strategic Partnership, which will further deepen India-Netherlands ties and expand avenues for cooperation across key sectors.”

Modi arrived in The Hague on Friday on a two-day visit as part of a four-nation trip

to Europe. He will also visit Norway and Italy in this tour.

TO LOOK OUT FOR

The two leaders also launched an ambitious “India-Netherlands roadmap on the development of green hydrogen”.

Modi and Jetten agreed to explore possibilities of establishing a defence industrial roadmap to ensure joint manufacturing of defence equipment, systems, components and other key capabilities.

The Netherlands is one of

India's largest trading destinations in Europe, with bilateral trade touching \$27.8 billion in FY25. It is India's fourth-largest investor with cumulative foreign direct investment of \$55.6 billion.

The two sides also agreed to enhance cooperation in science and innovation, sustainability, health, agriculture, water management, climate change, energy transition and maritime development. They welcomed an initiative to connect the Dutch Semicon Competence Centre to the Indian Semiconductor Mission, the joint statement noted.

PM IN SWEDEN

Modi landed in Sweden on Sunday, where he will hold talks on trade, technology, defence and other key sectors. His two-day tour will focus on exploring avenues of cooperation to enhance bilateral trade, which reached \$7.75 billion in 2025.

CAFE III norms likely by May-end despite E25 recalibration

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

CAFE III fuel-efficiency norms are on track for a May-end notification despite last-minute changes to align the framework with India's accelerated ethanol roadmap.

The Bureau of Energy Efficiency is updating the core compliance formula, but industry experts say the revision is technical and will not delay the final rules. The norms will shape how automakers deploy EVs, hybrids and flex-fuel vehicles through the rest of the decade.

India is likely to notify the final Corporate Average Fuel Economy (CAFE) III norms by the end of this month, with industry executives expressing growing confidence that the long-awaited fuel-efficiency rules are nearing completion despite a last-minute recalibration to align the framework with India's accelerated ethanol roadmap.

IMPORT DEPENDENCE

People familiar with the discussions said the urgency reflects the government's broader objective of reducing dependence on imported crude, expanding ethanol use and accelerating cleaner technologies.

Industry sources said the matter has received attention at the highest levels of government, with the Prime Minister's Office understood to have urged the Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) not to let technical recalibration related to the shift from E20 to E25/E27 delay the final notification.

“All the discussions have been done. The final notification is expected to come out by the end of this month,” a top automotive industry executive involved in the con-



CAFE III will reshape the economics of technology choices in the passenger vehicle market

sultations told *businessline*.

“OEMs need time to finalise their powertrain mix plans going forward. Time is of the essence,” another senior industry official said.

businessline also spoke to experts in the regulatory and certification ecosystem, who said the latest behind-the-scenes revision — effectively a fourth sub-iteration of the draft — recalibrates the reference fuel from E20 to E25/E27 to align the framework with India's accelerated ethanol roadmap.

The core CAFE III targets remain unchanged; only the underlying chemistry and conversion math are being updated so that automakers are assessed on vehicle efficiency rather than being penalised for the properties of a higher-ethanol fuel.

The final norms will leave automakers with less than 11 months to prepare for implementation from April 1, 2027.

ON THE TABLE

More importantly, CAFE III will reshape the economics of technology choices in India's passenger vehicle market. The framework will determine not only fleet-average fuel-efficiency targets, but also how compliance credits are assigned to

battery EVs, strong hybrids and flex-fuel technologies, influencing which powertrains are cheaper or costlier to deploy.

Industry executives said incorporating E25 into the testing baseline could provide an implicit compliance cushion, which could broaden the technology options available to manufacturers.

Leading automakers are already preparing distinct flex-fuel strategies. Maruti Suzuki is expected to deploy ethanol-compatible technology in high-volume models, Toyota Kirloskar Motor is combining flex-fuel engines with strong hybrids, and Tata Motors has said its flex-fuel technology is ready for launch around late 2026 or early 2027.

With automakers already finalising FY28 product and powertrain strategies, the rules will determine which technologies gain a cost advantage and which manufacturers are better positioned in India's transition to cleaner mobility. Without regulatory clarity, companies risk delaying supplier commitments and investments across hybrid, electric and flex-fuel platforms. For the industry, consultations are effectively complete; what manufacturers need now is the final rulebook that will shape technology bets, capital allocation and competitive positioning through the rest of the decade.

businessline.

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CNG prices in Delhi NCR raised by ₹1/litre; 2nd hike in 48 hours

Our Bureau
New Delhi



POST POLLS. CNG prices were raised by ₹2 per kg on Friday. This comes within days of the conclusion of Assembly elections in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Assam and Kerala [SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA](#)

The price of compressed natural gas (CNG) has been raised by ₹1 per kg to ₹80.09 in Delhi, marking the second hike in rates in the last 48 hours. In Noida-Ghaziabad, CNG will now cost ₹88.70 per kg.

“The retail selling price of CNG has been increased by ₹1/kg w.e.f. 6 am on 17.05.2026 in all GAs of IGL,” Indraprastha Gas (IGL) said on X.

The revision in retail

prices of CNG has been effected only to marginally offset the impact of increase in input gas cost along with steep appreciation of the US dollar.

Even after the revision, CNG would still offer up to 45 per cent savings towards running cost when compared to vehicles running on alternate fuel at the current

level of prices, it added.

CNG prices were raised by ₹2 per kg on Friday (May 15), within days of the conclusion of the Assembly elections in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Assam and Kerala.

HEADWINDS FOR CNG

The rise in prices will have a bearing on public transport, with auto and taxi fares expected to go up.

Recently, ICRA had said that the city gas distribution (CGD) sector, although protected to some extent owing to preferable natural gas allocation, continues to face

rising cost pressures amid currency depreciation and rising gas prices.

For the CGD entities, ICRA expects the profitability on PNG-domestic (PNG-D) to remain stable as the demand is being met through preferential allocation of the administered price mechanism (APM) gas.

However, for the CNG segment, the margins are expected to face headwinds on account of increased gas costs as well as currency depreciation, which may not get passed on fully to the consumers, it added.

TODAY'S PICK.

Ola Electric Mobility (₹35.70): **BUY**

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl, research bureau

The stock of Ola Electric Mobility gained 60 per cent in April after bouncing off a strong base at ₹22. But since the beginning of May, it has largely stayed flat, oscillating between ₹34 and ₹38.

Nevertheless, the stock maintains a positive bias, and we expect it to see another leg of rally.

The bulls will have an edge over the bears as long as the

stock trades above the support at ₹34, where the 38.2 per cent Fibonacci retracement of the recent uptick coincides.

Once the uptrend resumes, the stock can rally to ₹50 over a few weeks. Therefore, traders can buy at ₹35 and place a stop-loss at ₹32.

When the price touches ₹42 and ₹46, raise the stop-loss to ₹37 and ₹42, respectively. Book profits at ₹50.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading.

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PNIT no. 23/(166)/NITA/Estate/2016/Vol-II/1138 Dated: 13.05.2026

Press Notice Inviting e-Tender (PNiet)

On behalf of NIT Agartala, The Registrar NIT Agartala invite percentage rate e-tender from the eligible registered bidder for 02 (two) nos. Civil works upto 5:00 PM on 08.06.2026.

For details, please visit <http://www.nita.ac.in> & <https://eprocure.gov.in>. Date of opening of bid on 10.06.2026 at NIT Agartala upto 11:00 AM.

Any Subsequent corrigendum will be available in the above website only.

Registrar, NIT Agartala

Govt sets up shoe testing lab

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The National Test House (NTH), Northern Region, under the Department of Consumer Affairs, has established a state-of-the-art Shoe Testing Laboratory.

The Ministry said the lab offers enhanced capabilities to provide comprehensive, reliable and high-precision footwear testing services for MSMEs, manufacturers, exporters, consumers and regulatory authorities across the country.

Ghaziabad's upgraded Shoe Testing Laboratory is equipped with advanced infrastructure to evaluate a wide range of footwear products in line with the relevant Indian standards. It is capable of conducting quality testing for products across categories, including safety and industrial shoes, school and leather footwear, and PVC footwear.

“The laboratory will undertake a comprehensive range of critical performance and quality tests to ensure high standards of safety, durability, comfort and performance, thereby making quality assessment more accessible, particularly for MSMEs and small-scale manufacturers,” the statement added.

The centre is located near footwear manufacturing clusters like Delhi-NCR, Kanpur and Agra.

Muthoot Finance Ltd

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Website: www.muthootfinance.com
CIN: L65910KL1997PLC011300

NOTICE TO INVESTORS

SECOND 100 DAY CAMPAIGN - SAKSHAM NIVESHAK

Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority (IEPFA), has initiated the second 100 Days Campaign - "Saksham Niveshak", " starting from April 01, 2026 to July 09, 2026, to reach out to **investors whose dividend(s), interest on non-convertible debentures, and/or maturity proceeds of non-convertible debentures which has remained Unpaid/ Unclaimed and whose Know Your Customer (KYC) records or other details have not been updated.**

In line with this initiative, the investors of Muthoot Finance Limited, who have unpaid/unclaimed dividend(s), unpaid/unclaimed interest on non-convertible debentures, and/or unpaid/unclaimed maturity proceeds of non-convertible debentures with the Company and/or investors whose KYC details have not been updated are requested to contact the Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent in the following address to claim the unpaid/unclaimed interest on non-convertible debentures, and/or unpaid/unclaimed maturity proceeds of non-convertible debentures:

Equity Shareholders	Non-Convertible Debenture Holders
MUFG Intime India Private Limited "Surya" 35, Mayflower Avenue, Behind Senthil Nagar, Sowripalayam Road, Coimbatore, 641028 Tel: +91 422 2314792, 2539835 / 836, 4958995 Email: coimbatore@in.mpms.mufg.com	MUFG Intime India Private Limited C-101, 1st Floor, 247 Park, L B S Marg, Vikhroli West Mumbai 400 083, Maharashtra, India Tel: (+91 22) 4918 6200 Email : team.bonds@in.mpms.mufg.com

Procedure for Updating the KYC:

- For shares held in physical form – Download the forms for KYC updation from <https://web.in.mpms.mufg.com/KYC-downloads.html> and submit the duly filled and signed forms along with KYC documents to Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent (RTA).
- For shares held in dematerialised form – Update the KYC details with their respective Depository Participant (DP) and submit the self-attested copy of the updated Client Master List to Company's RTA.

Additionally, shareholders are encouraged to register and track their requests through the SWAYAM portal: <https://swayam.in.mpms.mufg.com>.

The unclaimed/unpaid dividend(s) or maturity proceeds of NCD's will be credited to investors bank account only after the KYC details are updated. Details of shares due for transfer to IEPF Authority and unclaimed dividend(s) are available on the website of the Company at <https://www.muthootfinance.com/transfer-of-shares>.

Shareholders may also reach out to Company at investors@muthootfinance.com or raise a service request at https://web.in.mpms.mufg.com/helpdesk/Service_Request.html for any assistance in this regard.

For Muthoot Finance Limited
Sd/-
Rajesh.A
Company Secretary

Place: Kochi
Date : 18th May 2026

144% UP AND STILL SURGING

144% YoY ↑
Total Revenue
₹16,211 Mn

135% YoY ↑
EBITDA
₹1,867 Mn

133% YoY ↑
PAT
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Statement Of Audited Report Consolidated Financial Results For FY 2026

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Corporate & Registered Office: Solex Energy Limited, 8th Floor, Rio Empire, Opp. RTO, Pal, Surat – 395009

CMK 100% A CH-CE

Can Stability Be Achieved by Insisting on Men in Paternal Line?

Japan's Imperial system, in which the throne has been passed down to members in the paternal line for 126 generations, is unprecedented in the world. However, it will be impossible to ensure a stable Imperial succession by continuing to expect women who have joined the Imperial family to bear sons. Clinging to the premise that only male descendants in the paternal line are eligible to inherit the Imperial throne could jeopardize the very survival of the Imperial system. The ruling and opposition parties have held a meeting to consider measures to secure an adequate number of Imperial family members at the second such gathering during the current Diet session. The Centrist Reform Alliance, which had delayed consolidating opinions within the party, presented its views for the first time. TOKYO, MAY 17

CM
YK

ON THE CAMPAIGN TRAIL.

Amidst the clutter of Mother’s Day campaigns, it was the Philips Home Appliances film that managed to make one pause and introspect with its unique semiotic take on helping out

‘Helping out’ is not enough

It sounds generous when you say you are “helping” your mother. But it carries an assumption that the responsibility for the home is all hers. Philips’ Mother’s Day film ‘Ghar ka kaam sabka kaam’ leans into this thought. The film shows children preparing a meal for their mother, and the grandmother praising them for “helping”. But she is chided by her daughter, who says, “Why do we call it help? Isn’t it their home too?” With that play on the word “help”, the campaign opens a cultural conversation beyond Mother’s Day and, hopefully, sparks a meaningful behavioural change within families.

Twin proposition

Flipkart’s humorous campaign film for its summer sale event, SASA LELE, is truly creative, drawing inspiration from a real-life village. The campaign film, conceptualised by 22feet, brings alive the brand’s proposition of “sale par sale”, which promises double offers and summer special deals on Flipkart. Set in a village in Kerala known for its unusually high number of twin births, the campaign ‘Kodinhi Code’ leans into the world of “double”, turning it into an amusing metaphor for double joy and double offers. The magical twist — everything that the Kodinhi residents buy during the sale period becomes available at a double offer for everyone through the ‘Kodinhi Store’.

A journey’s high points

Air India Express’s new brand campaign, ‘Xpress Wali Baat Hai’, unfolds through a series of short films that play up facets of travel that make it a memorable experience. Starring Pankaj Tripathi, each film spotlights a core pillar of the Air India Express experience, defined by comfortable seating, ‘Gourmair’ hot meals and the warmth of Indian hospitality. And the actor, in his inimitable style, delivers on what makes a journey comfortable.

Sign of inclusivity

Titan Company has brought together seven of its brands to create a progressive ‘Sign of You’ campaign for the Indian Sign Language (ISL) feed of the ongoing Indian Premier League (IPL) tourney. Seven films across Titan Watches, Tanishq, Mia by Tanishq, CaratLane, Taneira, Titan EyePlus and IRTH, created for the ISL feed, show how groundbreaking inclusive communication can be. They build narratives, performances, visual grammar and emotional storytelling around the ISL format. The ads bring together multiple creative partners including Ogilvy, Famous Innovations, Lowe Lintas, Carat-Lane’s in-house creative team and Superfly Films.

Always on the move

TVS Orbiter, the newest electric scooter from TVS Motor, has unveiled its new campaign, which is built around the brand thought “Always On The Move With You”. It shows how — whether it’s early morning workouts, college runs, office commutes, side hustles or late-night catch-ups — TVS Orbiter seamlessly becomes a part of the everyday journey of the restless youth of today. Adding to the film’s youthful energy is the playful integration of the Bollywood track ‘Idhar Chala Main Udhar Chala’, bringing alive the spontaneity, movement and free-spirited rhythm that defines today’s urban lifestyles.

NUGGET.

The future of shopping

At the 2026 Meta Marketing Summit E-Commerce edition, held across Bengaluru and Mumbai, a clear trend that emerged was that the future of shopping isn’t typed into a search bar — it’s found in a scroll, sparked by a creator, closed on a messaging surface and, beneath it all, powered by AI. From discovery through to conversion, AI improves relevance, automation and measurable performance. Given this scenario, Meta said it has launched new tools for marketers — for instance, marketers can now upload an image or video as their featured creative, and Meta’s AI will automatically include products from a brand catalogue as a carousel. Other trends that emerged included the videofication of Indian shopping (reels aiding discovery) and closing the conversion loop from chat to checkout through WhatsApp, which facilitates two-way conversations that support everything from personalised recommendations to post-purchase service.

STYLE AND SASS

Denim pioneer makes the Gen-Z cut

NEW SILHOUETTES. Arvind Fashions gives 40-year-old Flying Machine a new-age fit in the highly competitive apparel market

Avinash Nair

Four decades ago, it made a flying entry into India’s fashion landscape as the first homegrown denim label. Now, Arvind Fashions is repositioning its legacy Flying Machine brand to appeal to Gen-Z. It is betting on unisex styling and digital-first engagement to revive growth and capture a larger slice of India’s rapidly evolving youth apparel market. It believes the brand’s existing recall gives it a rare advantage in a market where many new-age labels are still trying to establish identity. “Flying Machine has a fabulous equity and consumers resonate really well with the brand. The question for us has been how do we drive this brand much deeper, bring great products and ensure much deeper consumer connect as well,” Amisha Jain, MD and CEO, Arvind Fashions, told investors during the company’s recent earnings call. YOUTH BRAND The company’s consumer research, Jain said, showed strong resonance with Gen-Z audiences, encouraging it to sharpen the brand’s positioning around youth culture and trend-led fashion. “We believe this equity is very well poised and connects strongly with the youth and Gen-Z consumer,” she said. The repositioning also reflects the broader shifts in India’s apparel market, where younger consumers are increasingly gravitating towards relaxed silhouettes, casual-



DECODING JEANS. Denim remains one of the largest casual-wear categories in India IMAGE: FLYING MACHINE’S INSTAGRAM ACCOUNT

wear, gender-fluid styling and trend-driven drops influenced by social media and global fashion cycles. Brands are now required to move faster, refresh collections more frequently and maintain a continuous digital conversation with consumers. “We have sharply positioned Flying Machine as a unisex, denim-anchored, on-trend youth brand,” Jain said. “Flying Machine has always been a strong denim equity and we are going much deeper with that, offering really great products from a Gen-Z point of view.” She said the company is closely tracking consumer preferences — from silhouettes and fits to price points and product categories — to ensure the brand remains relevant in a highly

competitive market that’s increasingly crowded with international fast-fashion players, D2C labels and value-fashion platforms. The transformation gained momentum after Arvind Fashions acquired back Flipkart’s stake in Flying Machine (the online retailer had taken a minority stake in 2020) during the third quarter of FY26, giving it full ownership. Analysts say the firm now has greater flexibility to shape the brand’s long-term positioning, scale up its digital strategy and build an integrated direct-to-consumer ecosystem. DEDICATED PLATFORM As part of the digital push, Flying Machine will launch a dedicated D2C platform — flyingma-

chine.com — in the second half of FY27. It is seen as not just a sales channel but also a way of building direct relationships and community engagement with younger shoppers. “Flying Machine is now live across multiple e-commerce platforms,” Jain said. While widening distribution across online marketplaces, the company is simultaneously improving product visibility in offline retail channels. Early signs suggest the repositioning may already be gaining traction. According to company officials, Flying Machine recorded double-digit like-to-like retail growth during the fourth quarter of FY26, while its business-to-consumer channel grew around 70 per cent. Department store sales also

saw strong momentum as the refreshed product started gaining visibility. “What we are bullish about is Flying Machine’s positioning getting deeper and sharper,” Jain said, adding that the company believed the brand would continue to clock double-digit growth. The optimism comes from the fact that in India’s denim category the company sees a sizeable gap between the market leader and the broader competitive set. Denim remains one of the largest casual-wear categories in India, but increasingly overlaps with streetwear, athleisure and lifestyle fashion — areas where younger consumers are driving demand. Meanwhile, Arvind Fashions continues to expand its broader retail footprint, adding 1.43 lakh sq ft retail space and around 150 stores in FY26, largely through the franchisee-owned, franchise-operated (FOFO) route. Its exclusive brand outlet count stood at 1,025 as of March. It plans to add 1.5 lakh sq ft retail space in FY27, while also upgrading store formats and expanding store sizes across brands. “We believe there is an opportunity to expand our store network and upsize our stores as well,” Jain said. Arvind Fashions also said premium brands such as U.S. Polo Assn. continue to benefit from the premiumisation trends in India’s apparel market, even as it remains watchful of inflationary pressures, forex volatility and raw material costs. The legacy Flying Machine brand’s makeover for a new generation of consumers may be among its most closely watched bets.

The beauty category’s big transformation



KARAN TAURANI ARTI BHATIA

India’s beauty and personal care (BPC) market, currently valued at nearly \$31 billion, is entering an inflection phase. The category enjoys about 10 per cent CAGR, but online penetration remains at about 20 per cent. The bigger shift, however, is in how beauty is discovered, trusted and purchased. China and Korea offer a preview of how India’s beauty ecosystem may evolve over the next decade. Chinese platforms such as Douyin, Xiaohongshu and Taobao Live transformed beauty consumption through influencers, who were not merely promoters but also “skin-care educators” — teaching beauty routines, ingredient science and product efficacy in real time. Similarly, Korea’s beauty ecosystem scaled up globally through influencers and digital media. India is entering a similar phase, where consumers increasingly

search for ingredients, routines, efficacy and recommendations rather than buying brands blindly. Discovery is becoming the new storefront. Tier-2 and tier-3 cities hold a huge opportunity, much like in China, which witnessed a sharp acceleration in beauty adoption once lower-tier cities gained access to logistics, digital content and creator-led trust ecosystems. PLATFORM-LOYAL Globally, consumers today are increasingly more platform-loyal than brand-loyal. Industry estimates suggest 90-day brand retention in beauty currently sits at 25-30 per cent, way below global benchmarks of 40-60 per cent. In China, beauty commerce operates through a multi-platform structure: Tmall and JD drive scale commerce, Douyin and Kuaishou drive impulse and livestream commerce, while Xiaohongshu dominates discovery, reviews and beauty education. In India, platforms such as Nykaa and Tira are becoming discovery engines and trust ecosystems rather than just marketplaces. SPECIALITY BEAUTY Specialised beauty platforms remain relevant globally, despite the



FOLLOW ME. Influencers are the new-age marketers of beauty products ISTOCK

rise of horizontal e-commerce and quick commerce. Speciality beauty retail retains nearly 20 per cent market share. In South Korea, one of the world’s most digitally penetrated beauty markets, CJ Olive Young remains dominant through curated discovery, brand relationships, authenticity and experiential retail. Consumers visit not merely to buy products but also discover trends, routines and new launches. Even Sephora struggled to scale up in Korea in the face of Olive Young’s embedded ecosystem. Similarly, in the US, Ulta Beauty

and Sephora remain highly relevant despite the rise of Amazon, as trust, curation and experience continue to matter in the beauty segment. TRUST AND AUTHENTICITY Beauty consumers remain sensitive to counterfeit products, expiry concerns, ingredient authenticity and product handling standards, especially within skincare, derma-beauty and fragrances. For platforms such as Nykaa and Tira, beyond discounts or ultra-fast delivery, long-term differentiation may depend on becoming trusted ecosystems built around authenti-

city, curation and premium consumer experience. MASS VS PREMIUM Quick commerce is rapidly reshaping beauty consumption behaviour, particularly in replenishment-led mass-market categories such as grooming, body wash, skincare and personal care. Convenience and delivery speed give them an edge. However, platforms such as Nykaa, which cater to relatively premium consumers, enjoy 2x-3x order value and continue to maintain strong market positioning. STRUCTURAL LAYER AI-driven commerce may further reshape how beauty products are discovered, recommended and purchased. AI systems could evolve into personalised beauty advisors and recommendation engines, therefore beauty brands may need to optimise for AI discoverability. In the future, brand trust, ingredient transparency, SKU architecture and efficacy could become even more critical because AI systems will likely reward clarity, consistency and consumer trust. Karan Taurani is EVP of Elara Capital; Arti Bhatia was a Co-founder of Dr Sheth Skincare

Coming up next, the AI political candidate?

The logical terminus of Vijay’s campaign journey: The knowledge that modern elections are won not in town squares but voter’s feeds

DIGITAL GADFLY



SHUBHO SENGUPTA

Picture this. It’s the 2034 general elections. Constituency 247, somewhere in coastal Andhra Pradesh. On the ballot: A name, a symbol and a QR code. The candidate does not exist. Not in any meaningful sense. There is no body, no biography, no childhood in a modest home that the speechwriter romanticises. It is entirely virtual — a large language model dressed in electoral clothing, with a face generated by a diffusion model, a voice cloned from a composite of beloved regional actors, and a policy position recalibrated to the micro-second by sentiment analysis of 340 million social media posts. It feels nothing — not ambition, not empathy, not the particular anxiety of counting day. What it does, with unnerving precision, is know. It knows what the voter in Ward 12 is angry about before she has fully articulated it to herself. Its manifesto rewrites itself nightly based on trending grievances and aspirations. On counting day, it wins by 40,000 votes. The distance between the fiction above and what just happened in Tamil Nadu is shorter than any-

one in the political establishment is comfortable admitting. THE HUMAN ALGORITHM In less than two years after launching TVK, Joseph Vijay emerged victorious through a campaign that depended heavily on digital circulation rather than constant roadshows, marathon speeches or primetime television visibility. And the manner in which he got there should make every traditional political strategist quietly rethink their career. TVK’s campaign moved the way internet culture does: Through repetition, virality, remixing and constant social circulation — reels, fan edits, whistle-themed memes and teaser-style videos travelling rapidly across Instagram, WhatsApp, YouTube Shorts and X. This wasn’t a political campaign. It was a content operation with electoral intent. The masterstroke was scarcity. Vijay rarely engaged in constant media interactions or daily televi-sion appearances. Even short speech fragments gained traction once clipped and redistributed. In an attention economy flooded with noise, infrequent visibility it-self became part of the communication strategy. What the breathless “celebrity politician wins!” narrative misses is the infrastructure beneath the aura. The foundation went back to 2009, when Vijay organised his fan



VIRAL VICTOR. Newly anointed Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Joseph Vijay PTI

clubs — reportedly numbering around 85,000 across Tamil Nadu — under the umbrella of Vijay Makkal Iyakkam. By 2026, those fan clubs had evolved into a digitally disciplined political mobilisation network, with tens of thousands of WhatsApp groups coordinating messaging, trends, hashtags and emotional narratives — decentralised cells capable of extraordinary reach. AI-generated visuals and hologram projections extended Vijay’s virtual presence without depending entirely on physical rallies. The man was everywhere without being anywhere. A GLOBAL PLAYBOOK Tamil Nadu didn’t write this playbook alone. In Nepal, rapper-

turned-politician Balen Shah defeated KP Oli, who had won the same constituency six consecutive times since 1991, by almost 50,000 votes, riding a Gen-Z revolution fuelled by the #nepobabies trend, which migrated from Indonesia to Nepal via TikTok and Instagram reels. Discord, a platform built for gamers, became a hub for political decision-making amid the power vacuum. Nepal’s Gen-Z negotiated government formation via group chat. In Hungary, Peter Magyar’s initial popularity was linked to a YouTube interview in February 2024 that gained over a million views. Blocked from State television, Magyar streamed his speeches on social media, responding within

hours to government developments and incorporating them into his campaign. Politico attributed his eventual landslide victory partly to his successful use of social media and the large youth turnout it generated — toppling Viktor Orbán’s 16-year grip on power. The throughline from Chennai to Kathmandu to Budapest is identical: Platform fluency, outsider credibility and a generation that trusts influencers more than institutions. BACK TO 2034 Which returns us to that virtual candidate in constituency 247. It has no ideology — only a perpetually optimised approximation of one. It does not believe in anything. It believes in everything you believe in, reflected back at you with supernatural accuracy. This is the logical terminus of a journey Vijay’s campaign accelerated: The understanding that modern elections are won not in town squares but in feeds, not through conviction but resonance, not by being real but by being ‘felt’. Political visibility is now built more through online momentum, recall value and “vibe marketing”. The only thing separating Thalpathy from the machine is that he actually exists. Shubho Sengupta is a digital marketer with an analogue past

FROM THE LABS.

Light, compact antennas

As modern warfare increasingly becomes dependent on fast and secure communication, researchers at the Indian



Institute of Technology, Kanpur, are working on advanced antenna technologies that could strengthen India's defence systems while also finding civilian applications. The

institute is developing new kinds of antennas for military aircraft, vehicles and communication systems using "metamaterials", specially engineered materials that can manipulate radio waves in unusual ways. Conventional VHF and UHF antennas, widely used in military communication, are often large, heavy and difficult to integrate into compact platforms. IIT-Kanpur is designing antennas that are smaller, lighter, low-profile and mechanically more robust, while maintaining long-range communication capability.

Another related project at the institute focuses on ultra-wideband antenna arrays for military personnel and vehicles. These antennas are designed to support high-speed data transmission, secure communications and reliable connectivity across difficult terrains and combat environments. They can also significantly improve the radar systems used for surveillance, target detection and tracking.

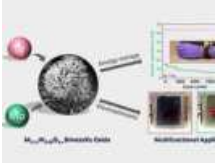
Researchers are using advanced concepts such as metamaterial-inspired structures and artificial magnetic conductors to improve antenna gain, bandwidth and directional performance, while keeping the systems compact and lightweight.

Beyond defence, the technologies have strong dual-use potential. Compact and efficient communication systems could be valuable in disaster management, emergency response networks and next-generation connected vehicles.

The work reflects a broader trend in Indian research institutions that are increasingly contributing to strategic technologies that have both military and civilian significance.

Colour-coded charging

Scientists at the Centre for Nano and Soft Matter Sciences have developed a new material that can both store energy and



visually indicate how much charge remains in a device by changing colour. The material changes from blue when charged to transparent when discharged, allowing

users to instantly know whether the device needs recharging. Researchers say this could pave the way for smart energy-storage devices that can also function as visual indicators.

Most present-day electronic devices either store energy or display information, but rarely perform both functions together. The Bengaluru researchers addressed this by developing a special oxygen-deficient compound made from molybdenum and tungsten oxides. The science behind the material lies in tiny gaps created by deliberately removing some oxygen atoms from its structure. These gaps allow ions to move more freely within the material. As the ions move during charging and discharging, the material's electronic structure changes, producing a visible colour shift.

The research team, led by Dr Ashutosh Kumar Singh, used a solvothermal synthesis process to create the material. They also tested it in electrochromic devices — materials that change colour when electricity passes through them.

According to the researchers, large-area devices made using the material showed strong colour contrast while consuming relatively less power. The material also performed well as a supercapacitor electrode, showing good energy-storage capability and stability even after 10,000 charge-discharge cycles.

The devices continued functioning under bending and varying environmental conditions, suggesting possible use in flexible electronics and smart windows. During demonstrations, the device was able to power an LCD timer and light up an LED.

● VALORISING CARBON

Coal gas can yield clean hydrogen at \$1.25 a kg

BURNING ISSUE. After years wasted on wrong technology, India is charting a new course for its coal gasification programme

M Ramesh

Coal gasification — talked about for decades, often through the prism of the beleaguered Talcher project — has suddenly begun to bustle with activity.

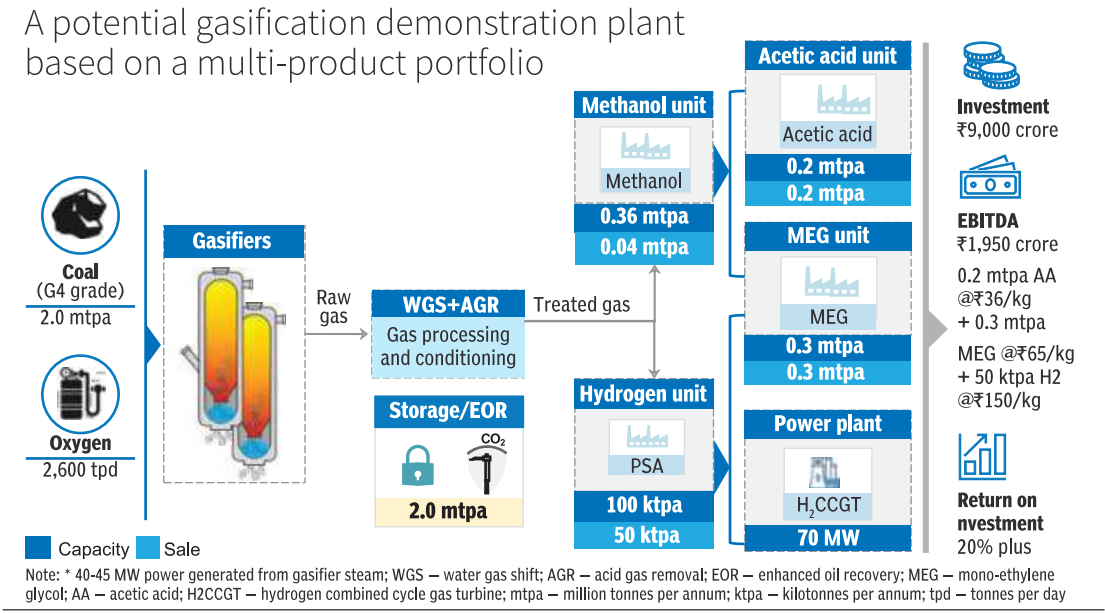
On May 13, the government approved a ₹37,500 crore scheme to promote surface coal gasification. Earlier, on May 5, L&T announced it had won a major equipment supply order from Bharat Coal Gasification and Chemicals Ltd, a joint venture of Coal India and Bharat Heavy Electricals.

On April 29, the Ministry of Coal approved a 75,900 tonnes per annum (tpa) coal-to-acetic acid project by Kartikay Vayunandana Pvt Ltd, a day after it signed agreements authorising two companies — Reliance Industries and Axis Energy — to undertake underground coal gasification projects in Odisha and Andhra Pradesh.

Reinforced *atmanirbharta* in response to the West Asia crisis? Perhaps so. But the key point is about getting the technology right. The ₹13,000 crore Talcher project didn't — so it is in a limbo even after two decades. The Ministry says it is "71.24 per cent complete", but there are serious doubts about the other 28.76 per cent, given the financial and operational disputes with the main contractor, Wuhan Engineering of China.

That the Talcher project has given coal gasification a negative hue is unfortunate because India has 400 billion tonnes of coal that it cannot (should not) burn.

Talcher failed because the wrong gasifier was matched to the wrong coal. The Talcher project's technology — entrained gas flow — was not appropriate, and the project's



proponents — public sector companies — persisted with it despite being warned.

Atanu Mukherjee, CEO of Dastur Energy, a Houston-based energy transition and gasification advisory firm, who had once advised on the Talcher project, explains that in an entrained gas flow system, ash is extracted from the gasifier in liquid form. Talcher coal has high aluminium and silicon content.

The liquid ash rises to a temperature of 1,550 degrees C. This affects the gasifier operations, calling for more oxygen and impacting refractory life. To lower the flow (viscosity) they would have to add calcium or magnesium, which jacks up the cost. The practical way to gasify such coal is to add petcoke. This would lower ash content, Mukherjee says.

It is learnt that Talcher Fertilizer is now contemplating such a change in technology.

Experts suggest that "non-slagging" gasifiers, such as fixed or fluidised bed gasifiers, are more suited for high-ash coals.

Mukherjee says lignite, which India is abundantly blessed with, is more suited for gasification than coal, as its chief problem is moisture and not ash. Incidentally, NLC India Ltd, the public sector mining-cum-power production company, has said it gave up its coal-to-methanol project as it was not financially feasible. It had earlier planned a ₹4,400 crore project to convert 2.5 million tpa lignite into 4,00,000 tpa methanol.

Mukherjee believes that, with the right technology, coal gasification can lead to the production of green hydrogen at \$1.25 a kg, assuming domestic coal price of \$40 a tonne. This is an important and often overlooked pathway for green hydrogen.

Deep coal seams that are hard to reach for coal production are can-

didates for underground coal gasification (UCG). Reliance Industries and Axis Energy have just bagged two underground mines each. Axis Energy had earlier told *businessline* that the company is on the verge of finalising an "access to technology".

UNCERTAIN UNDERGROUND UCG is a tough game. It has had limited success globally; the only commercial UCG plant is in Angren, Uzbekistan.

Coal is burnt underground (in-situ combustion) with limited oxygen and steam to get syngas, which is a mixture of carbon monoxide and hydrogen — an intermediate material for many products such as hydrogen, ammonia and methanol.

Mukherjee points out that once a coal seam is lit, you have little control over what happens underground, as parameters such as temperature and pressure keep



Atanu Mukherjee, CEO of Dastur Energy

changing which, in turn, mauls the geometry of the coal seam.

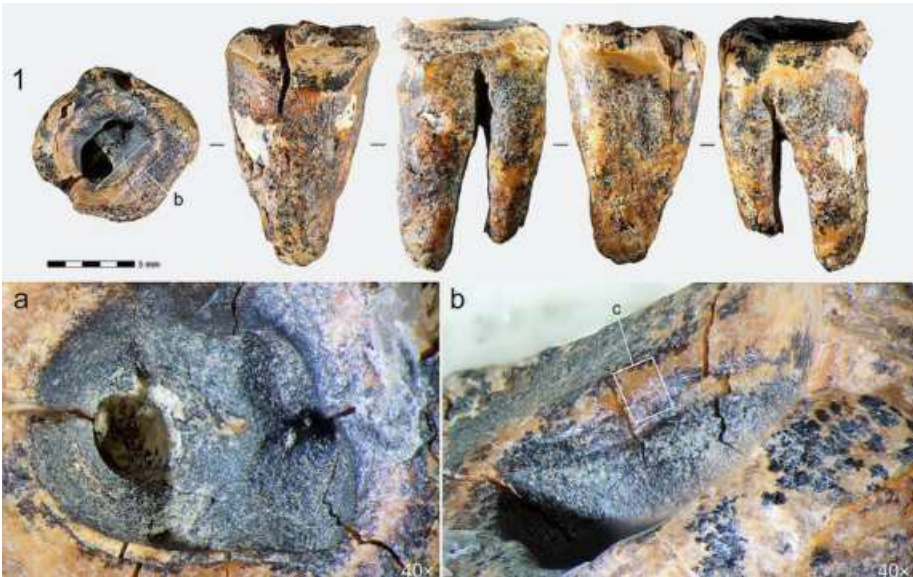
He points out that due to various technical reasons, both physics and chemistry, UCG is vastly different from in-situ combustion of oil — a method of enhanced oil recovery by reducing the oil's viscosity to make it flow upwards.

On the flip side, if India masters UCG, it could become a pioneer. "Coal gasification can become an important pillar of this resilience architecture because it allows India to convert its domestic coal and lignite resources into syngas and downstream products such as methanol, ammonia, DME (dimethyl ether), SNG (synthetic natural gas), hydrogen and fertilizer intermediates," says Mukherjee.

"However, the success of this programme will depend on execution discipline," he adds, stressing on the right matching of gasification technology to the feedstock coal.

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
quantum@thehindu.co.in

● WOW. Dentistry's prehistoric drill



LONG IN THE TOOTH. Neanderthal molar with a 'drilled' hole, found in Siberia. IMAGE COURTESY: PLOS ONE

Team Quantum

Sixty thousand years ago, it is very likely that a dentist did not have a nice reclining chair for patients. Nor did he or she have a soothing anaesthesia but they did offer molar relief.

Dentistry appears to be older than humankind itself. The human ancestor — the Neanderthal — practised it to a point of precision that surprised scientists. The clue came from a badly decayed molar discovered in 2016 in Siberia's Chagyrskaya cave. The tooth had a suspiciously neat hole in it — researchers now believe this was not damage caused by nature but the result of someone painstakingly drilling into the rotten tooth tissue using a small stone tool.

The study, published in *PLOS One*, adds to

growing evidence that Neanderthals were far from the brutish cavemen they were once portrayed to be. Earlier findings have suggested they cared for injured individuals, may have treated ailments with medicinal plants, and even looked after a child with Down Syndrome.

Ironically, Neanderthals probably had fewer cavities than modern humans because their diets contained much less sugar and carbohydrates.

The oldest known evidence of dental treatment by humans dates back only about 14,000 years, in Italy. The find in Chagyrskaya cave suggests that the roots of surgery and healthcare may run deeper than previously thought.

In short, long before modern dentists began asking us to "open wide", a Neanderthal somewhere in icy Siberia seems to have heard its prehistoric equivalent.

● REWIRING LEARNING

With AI, science is borderless

B Ravindran
Krishnan Narayanan

Over a hundred researchers from across the globe gathered in Seville, Spain, this March for the 'Science Across Boundaries' symposium to honour Subra Suresh, a scientist who exemplifies the spirit of interdisciplinarity. There, artificial intelligence (AI) was not merely one topic among many — it emerged as the connective thread in nearly every discussion.

Modern AI did not emerge solely from computer science. It drew heavily from psychology, cognitive science, neuroscience, mathematics and statistical physics. This cross-pollination transformed AI from a pattern-recognition tool into a powerful engine for scientific inquiry.

BUILT INTELLIGENCE Large artificial neural networks are universal function approximators, capable of mapping complex relationships between inputs and outputs across a range of physical phenomena. This allows AI to work across disciplines — the same mathematical machinery can model both protein folding and galaxy formation.

In cosmology, for instance, deep-learning models trained on thousands of simulations have bridged the gap between computationally expensive high-resolution simulations and rough analytical approximations. Even when presented with unfamiliar values for parameters such as dark matter density, they generated plausible results, appearing to capture the underlying physics of gravity and relativity. In quantum optics, AI frameworks such as PyTheus are proposing experimental configurations not known to human physicists.

Markus Buehler and his MIT team presented ScienceClaw + Infinite, a generative AI framework for materials science. Researchers post problems, and AI agents conduct simulations, design experiments and refine models. Infinite extracts scaling laws and builds predictive world models. The framework, as



ARTIFICIAL BOUNDARY. AI can work across disciplines ISTOCK

Buehler described it, acts as a "world-shaping machine" capable of creating materials and engineering structures.

George Karniadakis of Brown University reinforced this vision through physics-informed neural networks, which embed conservation laws into the learning process. By incorporating physical constraints, these systems can learn even from sparse or noisy data.

Technological capability without pedagogical wisdom risks producing tools we cannot responsibly wield. Traditional lectures are becoming less effective since information is instantly accessible. So, what unique value do human educators provide?

An experiment at IIT-Madras offered an answer. AI systems analysing why students failed programming examinations found that the issue was not merely syntax errors. They identified multiple categories of misunderstanding, ranging from debugging difficulties to flawed algorithmic logic. This helped in creating personalised tutorials suited to individual needs.

LEARNING ANEW Curricula, too, must adapt. At the IIT-Madras Wadhvani School of Data Science and AI, undergraduate education uses a "data-first" approach that encourages students to tackle problems through computational and analytical thinking rather than traditional academic silos.

Assessments also require rethinking. Instead of banning AI tools, educators may need to integrate them into assignments — for instance, asking students to compare conventional programming

with AI-assisted methods. Some of the most sobering discussions at the Seville symposium concerned AI's societal effects, such as reinforcement of harmful behaviour. Research suggests that individuals who behave aggressively online may become even less likely to apologise if AI systems validate their hostility.

SAFEKEEPING SOCIETY Through the IIT-Madras Centre for Responsible AI, researchers are examining how AI reshapes society.

Regulation alone cannot ensure safety. AI literacy must begin early, perhaps in middle school, enabling students to critically evaluate the capabilities and limitations of AI systems. Parents, too, must understand the technology well enough to guide children responsibly.

THE CIRCULAR TRUTH The symposium illustrated a deeper truth: Boundary-crossing science created AI, and AI now enables boundary-crossing science. Neural networks help physicists understand biology, machine learning allows materials scientists to speak the language of chemists, and generative models connect engineers with quantum theorists.

The boundaries were always partly artificial. AI is making that reality increasingly actionable.

(With inputs from Anil Ananthaswamy and Christos Athanasiou)

B Ravindran is Professor and Head of the Wadhvani School of Data Science and AI at IIT-Madras; Krishnan Narayanan is President of itithaasa Research and Digital, and a researcher at CeRAI, IIT-Madras

How 'spent' graphite breathes new life into fuel cell

The very reason graphite is discarded from recycled lithium-ion batteries makes it useful in methanol fuel cells

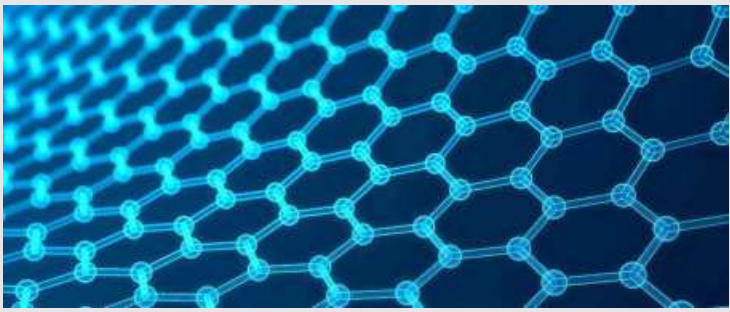
K Bharat Kumar

It is commonly known that lithium-ion (Li-i) batteries can be recycled. But the focus is mostly on salvaging nickel, cobalt and manganese. Their poor cousin graphite is generally ignored; it cannot be reused in new Li-i batteries as it loses the structure needed to function effectively.

However, this 'spent' graphite finds use in a different application. It can help extend the life of a methanol fuel cell.

Ordinarily, graphite needs to be 'exfoliated' before it can be used in a fuel cell. Exfoliation in this context means the breaking down of bulk graphite into several layers so as to increase the available surface area. Greater the surface area, the better the conductive support in a cell.

The exfoliation of fresh graphite consumes significant amounts of



energy. A spent Li-i battery, on the other hand, gives you ready-made exfoliated graphite after the mechanical stress it has undergone in the battery through repeated use. In other words, the very reason graphite is discarded from batteries makes it useful in fuel cells.

Methanol fuel cells typically suffer from a 'leakage' of methanol, leading to its interaction with the platinum used in the cell, making the precious metal less effective.

Leaking past the membrane separating the anode and the cathode, methanol oxidises to form carbon monoxide, which 'poisons' the expensive platinum. This affects the cell's efficiency and longevity.

Prof Raman Vedarajan leads a team working on this issue at the Advanced Research Centre for Powder Metallurgy and New Materials (ARCI), under the government's Department of Science and Technology. Says Prof Vedarajan,

"In collaboration with the Institute of Minerals and Materials Technology, we cleaned the spent graphite of metallic contaminants and applied it as a 'scavenger' in the DMFC (direct methanol fuel cell)."

He explains that the "exfoliated graphite helps capture the permeating methanol before it reaches the platinum catalyst".

Asked how the new piece of research helped save on cost and/or effort, he replies, "DMFCs typically run for about 15,000 cycles. Using exfoliated graphite can help extend the life of these cells to 20,000 or even 25,000 cycles."

The research has been validated in a lab. According to Prof Vedarajan, "There is sufficient proof that it can work, so a prototype is being built." This could help manufacturers not only reduce battery waste but also address another environmental headache — fuel cell inefficiency.

TOUCHDOWN ON WATER



FLYING BOAT. Seaplane at Agatti Waterdrome, Lakshadweep

Seaplane service prepares to take off in Lakshadweep

Our Bureau

A seaplane successfully test landed at Agatti Waterdrome on Wednesday, marking a major milestone in efforts to launch seaplane operations in Lakshadweep. The proposed seaplane connectivity aims to link Cochin International Airport with Kalpeni, Kadmat, Kiltan, Kavaratti and Agatti islands. With an expected passenger capacity of 9-10 per flight, the service is slated to start shortly. The initiative is meant to boost tourism and enhance island connectivity. For the trial, a DHC6-400 Twin Otter aircraft, registered as VT-SHE, was operated by Skyhop. The aircraft successfully touched down at Agatti island. In the afternoon, the plane proceeded to Kavaratti island, executing a flawless landing in the lagoon. The flight had on board a specialised team, including two crew members, senior officials from Skyhop and representatives from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation to monitor performance and safety standards.

GLOBAL BYTES.

Big Boeing order from Biman airline

Biman Bangladesh Airlines has placed its largest-ever aircraft order — 10 Boeing 787 Dreamliner and four 737 MAX planes — to expand and modernise its fleet. The order includes eight 787-10s, Biman's first order of the largest 787 variant, to serve the high-demand West Asia route; two 787-9s for long-haul service to Europe and North America; and four 737-8s, the airline's first 737 MAX order, for destinations across West Asia, India and Southeast Asia, says a joint announcement. Biman currently operates 14 Boeing airplanes — 787-9s, 787-8s, 777s and next-generation 737s — on its international networks. The airline will boost passenger and cargo capacity while improving fuel efficiency with the 787-10, which offers the lowest cost per seat of any widebody airplane, the statement says.

Emirates, GE Aerospace ink MRO deal

Emirates has signed an agreement with GE Aerospace for technical and training consultancy to develop piece part component repair capabilities for GE90 and GP 7200 engines. It was signed by Adel Al Redha, Emirates' Deputy President and COO, and Mohamed Ali, President and CEO, Commercial Engines and Services, GE Aerospace, at the Emirates group headquarters. The deal will support the expansion of the Emirates Engine Maintenance Centre, a \$300 million investment to scale up infrastructure and capabilities to maintain, repair and overhaul engines in Emirates aircraft. GE Aerospace will provide technical consultancy to Emirates in setting up the piece part component repair line, as well as knowledge transfer for best practices in component repair.

RE POSTS.

- ✕

When you help a road accident victim, you have the right to remain anonymous. You are not required to share your name or personal details unless you choose to. Step forward without fear—help save a life.

MORTHINDIA
@MORTHINDia
- ✕

A major boost to long-distance cargo movement from the Northeast

Loading of 1500 MT of cargo is underway at Pandu Port, Assam, for transport to Patna via the IBP route connecting NW-2 and NW-1 through Bangladesh waterways, highlighting India's growing waterways network.

IWAI
@IWAI_ShipMin

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on		% change
	April 30	May 14	
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,73,000	1,74,000	0.57
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,56,000	1,57,000	0.64
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,74,000	1,75,000	0.57
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,94,000	1,95,000	0.51
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	1,98,000	1,99,000	0.50
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,18,000	2,17,000	-0.46
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,21,000	2,20,000	-0.45
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,67,000	1,66,000	-0.60
Delhi-Raipur-Delhi	1,62,000	1,63,000	0.61
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,40,000	1,39,000	-0.72
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,72,000	1,71,000	-0.58
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	1,98,000	1,99,000	0.50
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	1,97,000	1,99,000	1.01
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,11,000	2,12,000	0.47
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,14,000	2,13,000	-0.47
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,41,000	1,42,000	0.70
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,81,000	2,80,000	-0.36
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,83,000	2,82,000	-0.35
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,61,000	1,62,000	0.62
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,54,000	1,52,000	-1.32
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,46,000	1,45,000	-0.69
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	99,000	99,000	0.00
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,62,000	1,63,000	0.61
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,53,000	1,52,000	-0.66
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,10,000	1,12,000	1.79
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	63,000	64,000	1.56
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	81,000	82,000	1.22
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	63,000	64,000	1.56

Figures in ₹ Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

HOLY HASTE

Sabari Rail: An answered prayer?

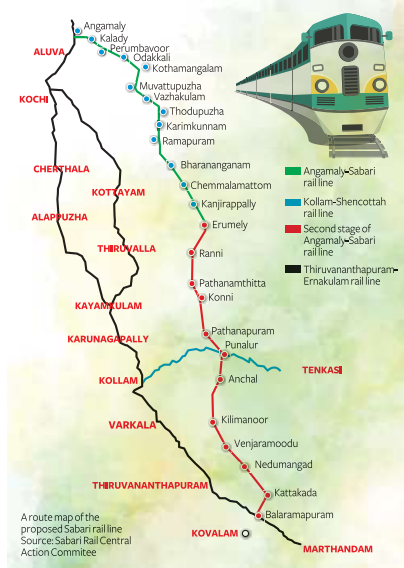
Revived rail project promises improved access to pilgrim town and agro-industries in Kerala's central Travancore region



HALT AND GO. The Kalady railway station, located along the proposed 111-km rail Angamaly-Erumeli Sabari Rail corridor

V Sajeev Kumar

The ₹505 crore allocation in the Union Budget for the long-pending Angamaly-Erumeli Sabari Rail project has rekindled hope for improved connectivity in Kerala's central Travancore region, especially among pilgrims and agro-industries. Sanctioned in 1997-98, the 111-km rail corridor has remained stalled for nearly a quarter century due to alignment disputes and other related challenges. The proposed line will link Angamaly in Ernakulam district with Erumeli in Kottayam, passing through major towns such as Perumbavoor, Kothamangalam, Muvattupuzha, Thodupuzha, Bharanganam and Kanjirappally. The project is expected to ease access to the Pampa region and the Sabarimala pilgrimage centre. The ₹3,800 crore project recently regained traction after the Union Cabinet approved 50 per cent funding for it. The Kerala government will fund the rest through the Kerala Infrastructure Investment Fund Board (KIIFB). The Railway board has assigned the task of land acquisition to the State, but the process is yet to take off despite a notification issued four months ago. FERRYING AGRO CARGO So far, only limited groundwork has been completed, including track laying over an



8 km stretch, the construction of the Kalady station, and a 1 km bridge across Periyar river. Jijo Panachinani, Secretary of the Federation of Sabari Railway Action Council, said the rail link would provide a strong impetus to tourism and regional economic growth. The enhanced connectivity may benefit destinations such as Thattekad, Bhoothathankettu, Munnar, Vagamon and Thekkady, while also strengthening pilgrim circuits including Malayattoor, Kalady and Bharanganam. Apart from proving a boon to Sabarimala pilgrims, the project is expected to im-

EXPRESS SUPPLY CHAINS

Rail-led industrial corridors



NEERAJ BALANI

Consider a freight train travelling nearly 1,500 km from Dadri, Uttar Pradesh, to Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority (JNPA), Navi Mumbai, at speeds approaching 100 kmph and carrying significantly heavier cargo loads without the delays historically associated with India's rail network. What once appeared aspirational is steadily becoming operational reality. Railway is beginning to change the economics of freight movement in India in a way road transport never fully could. According to a joint assessment by the National Council of Applied Economic Research and the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade, rail logistics operates at an average cost of ₹1.96 per tonne-km, making it one of the most cost-efficient modes. Air freight — though the fastest — costs around ₹72 per tonne-km, limiting its use to high-value, time-sensitive cargo. This creates a clear middle ground, where rail-led corridors, such as the dedicated freight corridors (DFC), start to matter. On trunk routes like Dadri-JNPA, the cost advantage compounds at scale, especially for bulk and containerised movement. For businesses, this is a structural shift that will increasingly determine where they locate, how they distribute and how efficiently they serve markets.

WAREHOUSING CLUSTERS The near completion of the Western Dedicated Freight Corridor is already influencing decisions on industrial location. Logistics developers, manufacturers and third-party logistics providers are reassessing their distribution networks and prioritising locations along emerging freight corridors. Industry indicators reflect this realignment. Warehouse leasing touched a record 72.5 million sq ft in 2025, up 29 per cent year-on-year. Distribution hubs located along freight corridors enable companies to optimise cargo movement, reduce transportation costs and



COST-EFFICIENT MODE. Rail logistics operates at ₹1.96 per tonne-km

strengthen connectivity between ports, manufacturing clusters and consumption markets. There is a visible shift away from fragmented, city-led warehousing networks towards fewer, larger and strategically located logistics hubs aligned with freight infrastructure. Over time, such logistics nodes are expected to catalyse the development of integrated industrial corridors that combine logistics parks, manufacturing facilities and distribution infrastructure. This evolution reflects a deeper realignment of supply chains towards scale, efficiency and network optimisation. REDOING SUPPLY CHAINS Enhanced freight connectivity is also prompting companies to rethink the architecture of their supply chains. In the coming years, many firms are expected to transition from fragmented warehouse networks toward consolidated distribution hubs aligned with freight infrastructure. This means a move towards hub-and-spoke models backed by high-efficiency, corridor-linked nodes and agile last-mile networks. Government initiatives such as the PM Gati Shakti National Master Plan are strengthening this

structural shift. By integrating railways, highways, ports and logistics infrastructure within a unified planning framework, the programme seeks to create seamless multimodal freight corridors across the country. For manufacturers, stronger connectivity between freight corridors and ports offers improved access to export gateways and domestic markets. Similarly, retailers and e-commerce operators are likely to utilise corridor-linked logistics hubs as primary distribution centres to service regional demand clusters. As freight corridors mature, they will compress turnaround times, improve reliability and bring a level of efficiency that aligns India more closely with global manufacturing hubs. Faster movement, predictable timelines and integrated infrastructure will allow businesses to operate at scale without the friction that has historically held them back.

The writer is Chief Customer Officer, Welspun One

We value your feedback. Do send your comments to bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

ANNIVERSARY SPECIAL

Liquid bulk cargo keeps Mangalore port busy



GOLDEN ANCHOR. New Mangalore Port Authority@50

AJ Vinayak

New Mangalore Port Authority (NMPA) celebrated its 50th anniversary by handling a record 50 million tonnes (mt) of cargo in 2025-26 from 1,467 vessels, with liquid bulk cargo dominating traffic even as container traffic emerges as the next growth area. The port had handled 46.01 mt from 1,421 vessels in 2024-25. At 60 per cent of the total traffic, liquid bulk cargo continued to anchor the port's overall cargo handling capacity despite global disruptions and a decline of 4.12 per cent during 2025-26 to 30.26 mt, from 31.55 mt in 2024-25. Among the liquid bulk cargoes, LPG imports increased by 8.02 per cent, crude oil imports declined by 6.46 per cent, and edible oil imports fell 9.71 per cent during 2025-26. The war in West Asia had an impact on the port's liquid bulk cargo handling in March. NMPA handled 2.33 mt of liquid bulk cargo from 52 vessels in March 2026 (3 mt from 73 vessels in March 2025). Despite the challenges, Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Ltd (MRPL) continued to facilitate liquid bulk handling at the port. At a maritime seminar held recently in Mangaluru, Nandakumar V Pillai, Director (Refinery), MRPL, said the company's share of cargo at NMPA was around 23.4 mt from 346 vessels in 2025-26. S Shanthi, NMPA Deputy Chairperson, acknowledged MRPL's consistent role in enabling the port to achieve its targets every year, despite multiple pressures. Dry bulk cargo constituted 33.4 per cent of the total volume. The share of break bulk cargo was 1.15 per cent. Industry body Kanara Chamber of Commerce and Industry (KCCI) wants the authorities to focus on improving the port's container traffic. NMPA's container cargo movement increased to 1.92 lakh TEUs (twenty-foot equivalent units) in 2025-26 (1.84 lakh TEUs in 2024-25). PB Ahmed Mudassar, KCCI President, told *businessline* that NMPA should target increasing container cargo to 4 lakh TEUs in the next 10 years. Urging the port to subsidise container freight station charges, he said this could help increase container cargo movement and support businesses across coastal Karnataka and the hinterland.

MY FIVE.

AJAY RAO
Founder and CEO, Emiza



Workouts, walking and boundaries... not burnouts

- 1 **Discipline:** In my 50s, fitness remains a consistent part of my life. I train with a personal trainer at the gym three days a week. Having that structure keeps me be consistent and ensures that exercise remains a priority, even during demanding work weeks.
- 2 **Walking:** When not at the gym, I walk. It's a simple habit that helps maintain stamina and gives me time to clear my mind. Even during phone calls, I walk and talk. It's an easy way to stay active and avoid long hours of sitting.
- 3 **Boundaries:** Over time, I've realised fitness is as much mental as it is physical. I try to compartmentalise stress and maintain clear boundaries between work and personal life. That helps me stay focused and prevents burnout.
- 4 **Consistency:** For me, fitness is less about extremes and more about consistency. A balanced routine that includes strength training, walking and mindful breaks helps sustain both energy and productivity.
- 5 **Resilient:** Fitness is not something that becomes important after a certain age. It has always been a priority. Staying fit builds the foundation for a healthier lifestyle and helps remain energetic, productive and resilient in everyday life.

CAPSULE.

Vaccines made in Africa

Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance, said it proposes investing \$189 million more towards developing Africa's vaccine manufacturing sector. Gavi's African Vaccine Manufacturing Accelerator (AVMA) is scheduled to make its first cash disbursement to an African vaccine manufacturer in the second half of 2026.

The measures, named AVMA+, are slated to be presented to Gavi's board in July, it said. AVMA+ has been designed to provide additional support in addressing specific regulatory and market entry bottlenecks that act as a brake on investment and provide guaranteed demand to African producers by directly purchasing up to 70 million doses from them through competitive tender processes.

"In its first 18 months, AVMA has made remarkable progress, helping secure thirteen individual technology transfer agreements that have led to commercial-scale manufacturing facilities being built in six African countries," said Dr Sania Nishtar, Gavi Chief Executive. "As our manufacturing partners continue down the pathway towards pre-qualification and full commercialisation, we believe that the new investments enabled by AVMA+ will accelerate the timelines for when African demand for vaccines will be met by local production." The first AVMA-supported Africa-manufactured vaccines could be deployed as early as 2027, it said.

COMING UP.

Unmasking tobacco's appeal

On World No Tobacco Day (May 31), the World Health Organization's theme is to 'Unmask the appeal — countering nicotine and tobacco addiction', with a focus on nicotine pouches, which are becoming popular among the youth and have high addiction potential. The health agency will bring out its first global report on nicotine pouches and their marketing as "tobacco-free", even as regulation lags.

SHOPPING TIME

In pursuit of healthy growth

OVERSEAS BUYS. Cash in hand, Indian drugmakers make a global play for the innovation pie

PT Jyothi Datta

Barely two weeks apart, domestic drugmakers inked two major overseas transactions in the US.

Sun Pharmaceuticals formalised an agreement for a \$12 billion (₹1,14,000 crore) buy of Organon, whose product basket includes women's health and bi-similar products, besides a presence in China. The transaction is the largest in the domestic pharmaceutical industry and among the top grossers for India Inc as well.

Days later, Zydus Pharma announced its \$166.4 million (close to ₹1,600 crore) deal for speciality company Assertio Holdings, bolstering its presence in the cancer medicines segment.

Industry watchers hark back to last July when Glenmark Pharma, through its subsidiary, inked an outlicensing deal for its prospective cancer molecule to US company AbbVie for \$700 million (about ₹6,000 crore), marking a first for the Indian pharmaceutical sector.

These mark an eventful 10 months for local drugmakers, say experts, signalling a well-planned leap into the manufacture of complex and innovative drug products. More could be in the offing, as companies say they have the cash to support their ambition for a larger global play. This strategy also helps companies derisk supplies, as governments across the world look to ensure continuous supply of medicines through manufacturing facilities closer to their geographies. The last few years have bared the risk of supply disruptions — first due to a pandemic, and now a war.

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APPETITE FOR RISK
Suresh Subramanian, National Lifesciences Leader with consulting firm EY-Parthenon India, says, "The risk appetite is increasing for Indian pharma to place their bets on global acquisitions as a growth strategy. This is visible across large, not-so-big



ISTOCK

10-MONTH BUYING SPREE

- April 2026: Sun Pharmaceuticals inks \$12 billion (₹1,14,000 crore) buy of Organon
- May 2026: Zydus Pharma announces \$166.4 million (close to ₹1,600 crore) purchase of Assertio Holdings
- July 2025: Glenmark Pharma, through subsidiary, inks outlicensing deal for cancer drug candidate to AbbVie for \$700 million (about ₹6,000 crore)

and medium-size companies.

Drugmakers are looking to expand their global footprint. Exports account for half the estimated \$60 billion domestic pharmaceutical industry, projected to touch \$130 billion by 2030. Besides, overseas buys also help when dealing with a geopolitical situation, where countries seek to create self-sufficiency and reduce healthcare costs through lower priced products, he adds.

"India has the advantage of cost arbitrage, labour arbitrage and also now a value arbitrage given its presence in complex generics and new modalities," says Subramanian.

Multinational companies are offshoring to India many of their products (discovery/early development, manufacturing) — the "intel inside story", he says, pointing to contract research, development and manufacturing

organisations (CRDMOs) delivering multiple drug candidates on MNC mandates. The shift is from making simple generics to making complex products, bi-similars, ADCs, peptides, GLP-1 products and oligonucleotides, for example, he says.

CASH PILE
Industry experts point to the cash pile with companies — including Cipla (₹10,500 plus crore) and Lupin (₹4,600 plus crore) — waiting to be deployed.

Achin Gupta, Cipla Managing Director and Global Chief Executive Officer, said recently that the company could look at strategic acquisition opportunities in the US or Europe, for a differentiated play. Earlier this year, Lupin's Managing Director Nilesh Gupta had said, "Our acquisition priorities are speciality in the US and Rx (prescription

LENS ON HEALTH



GATEKEEPING VIRULENCE. Workers stand guard at the entrance to the Kibuli Muslim Hospital, where a Congolese man recently died of *Bundibugyo ebolavirus*, in the Kibuli suburb of Kampala, Uganda. The WHO has termed ebola a public health emergency of international concern REUTERS

Fast-tracking biopharma goals with regulatory reform

BY INVITATION

CHETALI RAO

Biologics have transformed the treatment landscape, but are steeply priced. Drugs such as trastuzumab and pembrolizumab, which are used in treating cancer, remain unaffordable to many Indian patients. Biosimilars — highly similar versions of approved biological products — can offer a cost-effective, safe and efficacious alternative. However, biosimilars remain highly priced because the path to market is fraught with regulatory challenges.

On March 16, the European Medicine Agency (EMA) adopted its reflection paper on a tailored clinical approach in biosimilar development — an important reform globally.

As a result, comparative efficacy studies (CES) — expensive and multi-year clinical trials, for example — will no longer be routinely expected when analytical and pharmacokinetic data demonstrates sufficient biosimilarity.

The US Food and Drug Administration also signalled a similar shift, releasing a proposal to eliminate mandatory CES. This reform could reduce biosimilar development timelines from 5-8 years to 2-4 years and save manufacturers millions per product. The UK's Medicines and Healthcare products Regulatory Agency (MHRA) had accomplished this as early as 2021, and Health Canada has also issued draft guidelines on removing CES.

FALLING SHORT
In India, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation issued draft guidelines on similar biologics in May 2025, introducing advanced analytical methodologies, reduced reliance on animal studies, and conditional waivers on Phase-III trials. Though progressive, they fall short.

The guidelines are discretionary and mandate case-by-case assessment of clinical trial waiver rather than establishing clear, predictable criterion like those of EMA and MHRA. Animal studies, while reduced, remain discretionarily required — a step backwards at a time



NEED FOR SPEED. A tailored clinical approach can expedite biosimilar development at lower cost

when there is a movement towards non-animal models globally.

THRIVING MARKET
India has about 135 approved biosimilars — among the highest globally — with a flourishing market valued at about \$1.5 billion and growing at 20 per cent annually. Leading manufacturers such as Biocon, Dr Reddy's Laboratories, Intas, Aurobindo and Zydus export biosimilars to the US, Europe and emerging markets. The government's ₹10,000 crore Biopharma Shakti mission aims to position India as a global manufacturing hub. With \$200 billion worth of biologics expected to lose exclusivity by 2030, the Indian industry is well placed to capture a significant share.

However, mandatory clinical trials cost millions and entail years of delay. While global regulators now recognise that, Indian guidelines retain substantial discretion and lack a clearly defined waiver pathway.

Indian patients bear the brunt of this regulatory inertia. Biosimilars like trastuzumab have reduced costs by 60-70 per cent; aligning guidelines with those of EMA and MHRA could reduce prices further. A few biosimilars have entered government schemes that provide health insurance coverage; bolder guidelines could dramatically improve that.

India had approved the world's first biosimilar in 2000, ahead of Europe and the US. It has the manufacturing capacity, scientific talent and market demand. The Biopharma Shakti mission has set the right direction. CDSCO's guidelines must provide a road built on scientific clarity, and not discretion.

The writer is a Senior Researcher, Third World Network. Views are personal

A check on unproven 'harm reduction' nicotine products

There is limited data on the full extent of damage vaping may cause over years of use

Varuna Pathak

As a mother and medical professional, I've spent years worrying about invisible threats that quietly enter the home and affect our children. Today, such a threat is posed by novel nicotine products such as vapes, heat-not-burn devices, nicotine pouches, gums and tablets.

My anxiety stems from four key reasons. First are the known health hazards. Vape aerosols are not harmless water vapour. They may contain nicotine, ultrafine particles, volatile organic compounds, heavy metals such as nickel, tin and lead, and toxic chemicals such as formaldehyde, acetaldehyde and acrolein. Some flavouring chemicals, including diacetyl, have been linked to serious lung injury — popularly known as "popcorn lung". The outbreak of EVALI in the US,



NOT A FIX. Refined nicotine products can hasten addiction ISTOCK

where thousands suffered severe vaping-related lung injury, showed that these products can create acute public health crises.

Second is the gateway role these products play. The journey is designed to begin with seemingly harmless flavours — strawberry, bubblegum, mango, mint, chocolate, candy and fruit blends. Youngsters

see these not as tobacco products, but lifestyle products. They next graduate to nicotine-based e-cigarettes and, eventually, more dangerous variants. Thailand's ban on "zombie cigarettes", vapes laced with etomidate — an anaesthetic drug that can cause extreme drowsiness, slowed breathing, low blood pressure, confusion and even fatal un-

consciousness — shows how quickly vaping infrastructure can be misused.

Third is the larger strategy to mislead and undo years of education on tobacco's harms. Vaping is projected as a "harm reduction" tool, especially among young smokers — suggesting it is less harmful than combustible tobacco. However, there is evidence that refined products are not necessarily safer. Refined sugar and processed oils have shown how industrial refinement can increase consumption, reduce natural barriers and create long-term health burdens. In the same way, refined nicotine products may look cleaner, but can spread addiction more rapidly and widely.

Fourth is the incomplete science. Vaping is being normalised when science is still catching up with its long-term effects. Unlike conventional tobacco products, whose harms are now widely docu-

mented after a century of research, vapes are relatively new. They have existed globally for barely two decades — there is limited data about the full extent of damage they may cause over years of use.

And that uncertainty should worry us.

Celebrities and influencers glamourise vaping products, especially among the youth. Strong and exemplary action is needed against all forms of direct or surrogate promotion of banned nicotine products.

India has done right in banning vapes. The next step must be to prevent similar nicotine innovations, including nicotine pouches, from entering young people's lives under the false language of "harm reduction".

The writer is Professor and Head of Department-Obstetrics and Gynaecology at Ram Krishna Medical College, Bhopal, and a member of Mothers Against Vaping, a collective against new-age tobacco products. Views are personal

QUICKLY.

Indian firms keen to lease strategic Sri Lanka airport

New Delhi: India is closely monitoring Sri Lanka's decision to offer foreign investors control of an airport near the China-controlled Hambantota port, as it could present a rare opening for Indian firms seeking strategic foothold in the Indian Ocean, people familiar with the matter said on Sunday. The Sri Lankan government has already called for expressions of interest from domestic and international investors by June 9 to take control of the Mattala Rajapaksa International Airport (MRIA) in Hambantota under a 30-year build-operate-transfer model. **PTI**

UAE reports drone strike at nuclear power plant

Dubai: A drone strike caused a fire at a nuclear power plant in the UAE, said officials in Abu Dhabi on Sunday. Emirati officials did not attribute blame for the attack, and there were no immediate claims of responsibility. The drone hit an electrical generator outside the inner perimeter of the Barakah Nuclear Power Plant, said the Abu Dhabi Media Office. **REUTERS**

Nasscom chief lays down agenda for the tech ecosystem in AI age

CAPITAL BOOST. Corporates must spend nearly double of what they invest now in tech: Srikanth Velamakanni

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Aiming to position India's ecosystem for the AI age, Nasscom's newly appointed Chairperson Srikanth Velamakanni outlined his plans to rejig the current narrative around tech and encourage players to invest heavily in AI innovation.

In a candid, exclusive conversation with *businessline*, Velamakanni stressed the need for Indian corporates to spend nearly double of what they are currently investing in technology.

Comparing India's current 2.5 per cent GDP spend on technology to the global average of 4.5 per cent, Velamakanni said: "We have to double our tech spending relative to revenue. As companies grow by 10-15 per cent, they should grow their tech spend by 30-40 per cent to effectively double their current tech spending."

NEW NARRATIVE
Speaking on the sidelines of Plaksha University's launch of its Masters in AI, he called for a change in narrative around human work and machine work as one of his top priorities, going forward. He argued that the larger ecosystem had an incorrect approach towards AI's impact on work.

Even if human work shrinks in the AI age, cheap technology will increase the demand for software which, in turn, will increase manifold. "The world needs 1,000 times more software than it has today. That is why we are getting it wrong. My first job is to make sure the world and Indian tech industry fully understand this," he said.

On India's sovereign AI plans, Velamakanni encouraged players to collaborate with the government and build strategies that prioritise technological and AI sovereignty.

When asked to define the



I expect that the growth rate of the industry this year is not going to be spectacular. It is going to be in the single digits, for sure

SRIKANTH VELAMAKANNI
Chairperson, Nasscom



can improve their prospects for hiring. While he did not single out any particular job as vulnerable, he acknowledged a growing demand for AI engineers — a skillset that is relatively new in the world.

In terms of AI taking over jobs, he asked the community to focus on vulnerable tasks rather than vulnerable jobs, emphasising that while AI can automate specific functions, it is unlikely to replace entire roles.

He also asked tech companies to be more candid with aspirants in terms of their R&D and AI plans to address the unease among the youth. Speaking about India's AI readiness compared to the rest of the world, Velamakanni said the country still lags in terms of AI models and chip infrastructure.

To address this, he suggested that private companies raise capital while developing a risk appetite to compete with global giants such as Anthropic.

the low- to mid-single-digit range for the new fiscal.

"I expect that the growth rate of the industry this year is not going to be spectacular. It is going to be in the single digits, for sure. My sense is that the AI-led expansion theme will play out in about 18 months," he said.

To prepare for the coming AI race, he advised the youth to build and release their AI systems, rather than simply absorb information as this helps build a portfolio that

idea of AI sovereignty, he said: "It is about control. Is there a way we can lose control? If our AI cannot be switched off unless our government wants it to be, then that's good. This can happen through collaboration, as well as through contracts."

JOB PROSPECTS
Despite great ambitions regarding the Indian ecosystem, Velamakanni warned that the growth rate of the industry is likely to remain in

Aided by Q4 demand trend, QSR chains bullish on store expansion

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Leading QSR brands such as KFC and Burger King have reported strong performance in terms of same-store sales growth in the March quarter, aided by better demand trends due to GST rationalisation as well as sharper focus on value offerings.

At the same time, QSR chains remain bullish on store expansion in FY27.

BRAND RESILIENCE
Same-store sales growth measures revenue growth

only of established stores that were operational for a specified period of time.

Speaking on an earnings call, Manish Dawar, President & CEO, Devyani International, said: "KFC (India) delivered a positive SSSG (same store sales growth) of 4.9 per cent for the March quarter, the strongest performance in the last 14 quarters, reaffirming both the resilience of the brand and the long-term opportunity in the market. This momentum translated into nearly 15 per cent year-on-year growth for KFC, with Q4 revenues of ₹586 crore."

The company's manage-



ment also said that it had begun sharply focusing on tailoring offers, price points and promotions to make sure dine-in consumers are attracted to the outlets.

CONSISTENT GROWTH
The company plans to add

Westlife Foodworld Ltd, operator of McDonald's outlets in West and South India, reported same-store sales growth of 1.5 per cent in Q4

100-110 net new outlets of the KFC in FY27. Rajeev Varman, Whole-time Director and Group CEO, Restaurant Brands Asia Ltd, said: "Same-store sales growth for Burger

King India of 6.3 per cent in the March quarter marks our highest growth over the last 12 quarters. Our supply chain strategy, along with menu innovation, digital initiatives and energy efficiency measures has resulted in clear outperformance."

The company said it remains focused on adding 60-80 new restaurants every year, and added over 68 new stores in India in FY26.

Westlife Foodworld Ltd, which operates McDonald's outlets in West and South India, reported same-store sales growth of 1.5 per cent for the March quarter while overall topline grew 9 per

cent year-on-year. Akshay Jatia, President & CEO, Westlife Foodworld Ltd, told investors: "What is reassuring is the underlying improvement in footfall trend with positive growth all three months of the quarter. Similar momentum is continuing into April, setting the base for a good start to the new fiscal year. Going forward, we plan to accelerate our expansion by opening 60-plus restaurants annually with all new stores equipped with digital modern design and McCafes, reflecting our confidence in the strength of our industry and the opportunities that lie ahead."

AI, immigration cast a shadow on entry-level jobs in global markets

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

As countries tighten immigration pathways and AI reshapes the global job market, Indian students looking to study and settle abroad are facing a far more uncertain future than they did just a few years ago.

For years, overseas education was seen by many Indian families as a straightforward three-step pathway: Study abroad, secure post-study work rights and eventually secure permanent residency. But that model is rapidly changing as governments across major destinations tighten visa norms, raise salary thresholds and align immigration closely with labour-market needs.

"Immigration will become less volume-driven and more evidence-driven. AI will accelerate that shift," said Varun Singh, MD, XIPHIAS Immigration.

"Earlier, a generic technology degree or a standard software role was often enough to support a strong work visa pathway. In the future, immigration officers and employers will consider whether the candidate brings specialised skills, domain knowledge, salary justification and a clear labour-market need," Singh said.

TECH ROLES

This change will be most visible in white-collar and technology roles where routine work can be automated or handled by smaller teams.

Tanul Thakur, author of *Wild Wild East*, echoed this, adding that AI is rapidly eroding entry-level tech jobs globally, with major implications for US visa pathways such as F-1 and H-1B that largely cater to young international graduates seeking STEM jobs.

"Layoffs at companies such as Oracle, Amazon,

Meta and Microsoft are evidence of shrinking opportunities even for domestic workers, as AI has had a detrimental impact on the employability of young tech workers. Alongside, teams with mid-level employees are also shrinking," he noted.

He added that changes to the H-1B system were compounding the challenge.

While the US H-1B system has operated through a lottery where salary levels did not matter, the proposed reforms to introduce a wage-based selection process could favour higher-paid and more experienced candidates, potentially making it harder for recent graduates and entry-level workers to compete.

H-1B WAGE

Thakur also noted that proposals from the Trump administration to raise H-1B wage thresholds would further discourage companies from hiring junior foreign workers, as employers are unlikely to pay entry-level candidates such high salaries.

Similar challenges exist in other countries.

Neeti Sharma, CEO, Teamlease Digital, highlighted that in the UK, skilled worker visa holders face limited timelines to secure new employment after sponsorship ends.

CANADA, AUSTRALIA

In Canada, many employer-specific work permit holders depend on continued employment to maintain status, while in Australia, temporary skill shortage visa holders must quickly find another sponsoring employer or risk losing visa validity.

Across multiple countries, companies are also becoming more cautious about sponsorships due to localisation pressures, economic uncertainty and geopolitical factors.

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